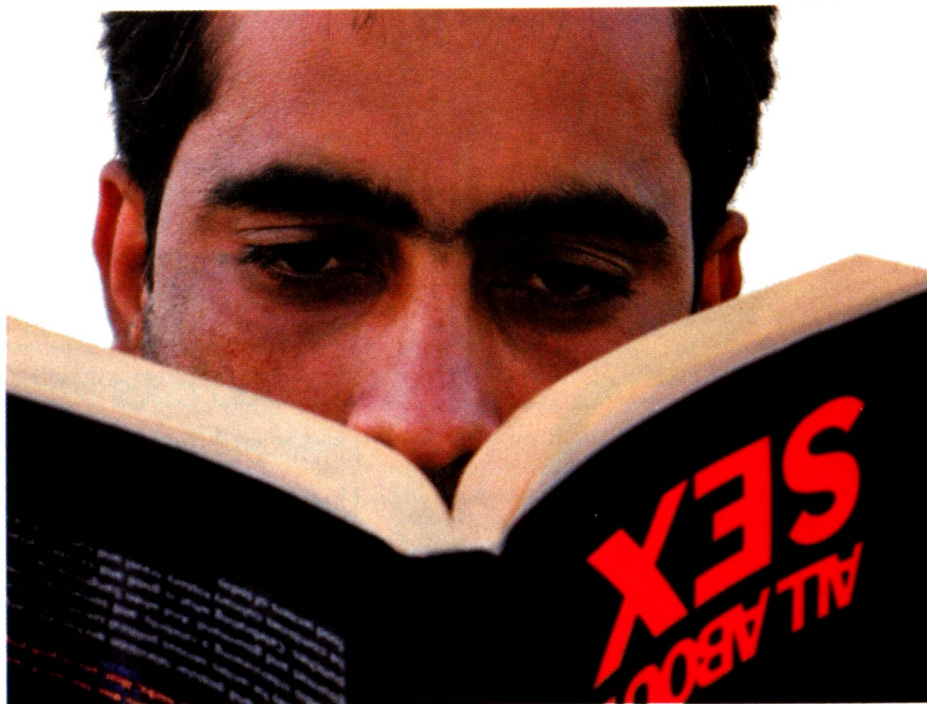


Photo illustration BY SAURABH SINGH and Photograph by HEMANT CHAWLA



70% OF CALLERS ARE BELOW 30 YEARS AND 33% BETWEEN 15 AND 24 YEARS OF AGE.

The questions range from, "I did not use a condom. Will I get AIDS?" to "Can I get AIDS from mosquito bites?"

"My listeners seem to celebrate sexual openness and uninhibited expression."

ANIL SRIVATSA, COO, MEOW



and cable, began appearing in Indian homes—Mitch Buchannon's *Baywatch* babes, Rose and Jack's steamy coupling on the doomed *Titanic*. For the first time, sex, affairs and divorce were discussed openly, as scantily clad divas shimmied and couples kissed passionately on screen. Within a decade, Indian TV has opened up its own space for sex. Navin Parekh, 35, a Mumbai stockbroker and an insomniac, tunes in to a talk show every night, where anonymous callers thrash out their intimate sexual maladies with experts: does obesity get in the way of pleasure, is self-gratification harmful, do aphrodisiacs work, is homosexuality contagious? They may or may not add to Parekh's knowledge bank, but the readiness of Indians to discuss sex with perfect strangers mesmerises him: "I didn't know Indians could be so candid about sex."

For Sumedha Sinha, 28, who grew up in conservative Meerut—where hand-holding brings down the wrath of the gods every Valentine's Day—the public display of affection was quite

a shocker once she took up a job and started living alone in Delhi. She remembers the first time she went to one of the "cool" discotheques in the capital. "As my eyes got used to the dim lighting, I caught silhouettes of couples kissing, touching, and necking openly, both on and off the dance floor," she recalls. A regular nightclubber now, such scenes don't affect her anymore.

Sex is getting a lot more attention in legal circles too. Since 2006, the Supreme Court has given sexual incompatibility a lot more credence as a ground for divorce. Last year, the Delhi High Court annulled a 13-year-old marriage for the same. Hari Pillai, a lawyer who deals with matrimonial cases in the capital, comes across a lot of young people who want to part on sexual issues: "Earlier, the common reason for divorce was mental or physical torture but now it has more to do with incompatibility," he says.

These are signs of increased sexual awareness and a more liberated society. Yet, ignorance and misconception dominate the landscape. Unlike

their more uptight, relationship-oriented predecessors, the threat of AIDS looms large over the sexual encounters of today's youth. The AIIMS clinic gets flooded with calls and mails: from "I did not use a condom. Will I get AIDS?" to "Can I get AIDS from kissing," or "from mosquito bites?". Singh also notices a rising trend of young people wanting to get married after going through HIV tests.

It's well past the normal work-hour at AIIMS. But lights are on at the old OT block, as Singh goes through the daily pile of e-mails. An old Kishore Kumar number plays on the music system, "*Zindagi, kaisi hai paheli...*". An e-mail reads: "Promise, I'll never do it again. But how will I tell my parents if I get AIDS?" He sighs and massages his temples. A new sexual awakening? In the last five years, the trickle of calls and mails have morphed into a flood. Now, the anxiety is rising to a fever-pitch. Will the painful rite of passage lead to a brave new world? With the next pre-marital counselling session slotted for October 21-22 at AIIMS, he certainly hopes so. ■